

A daily scan of national and South Yorkshire developments in education policy, inclusion, SEND, behaviour and accountability — weighted to primary and evidence sources, with links and a clear “so what for your school” line on the items that matter.

Useful? Forward it to a colleague. To join the circulation or partner with the network, [get in touch](#).

TOP LINE

- The DfE has told the NEU that this year's 3.5% teacher pay rise will be fully funded after all, via roughly £500m freed up by lower local government pension contributions — potentially averting the strike ballot due to open on 3 October.

→ **For your school:** *NEU's national executive meets on 24 September to decide whether to stand the ballot down.*

- Newfield Secondary's first Ofsted report since Mercia Learning Trust's 2025 takeover rated attendance/behaviour and inclusion at 'strong standard', a marked turnaround from last year's parent and pupil protests over curriculum cuts.

→ **For your school:** *A useful local case study on inclusion recovering after a difficult MAT transition.*

DATES FOR THE DIARY

18 Sep 2026 — DfE's twin SEND/EOTAS reform consultations close tomorrow — last call to respond before proposals are firmed up.

NATIONAL POLICY & FUNDING

- **Teachers' pay rise now fully funded, DfE confirms.** Education secretary Lucy Powell told the NEU that recent local government pension scheme revaluations free up roughly £500m for schools this year, meaning the pay award won't need to come out of existing budgets after all. The NEU's national executive meets on 24 September to decide whether to stand down its planned ballot. ([Schools Week](#))

→ **For your school:** *Worth holding off on any budget-planning adjustments until the 24 September decision is confirmed.*

BEHAVIOUR & ATTENDANCE

- **Suspension rates keep falling — but the disadvantage gap doesn't.** New FFT Education Datalab analysis of autumn term 2025/26 finds secondary suspension and exclusion rates still falling, extending last year's post-pandemic reversal, while primary years 1-4 saw a small rise. Disadvantaged pupils remain far more likely than their peers to be excluded or suspended. Figures are FFT's own analysis, flagged here as provisional pending the DfE's official autumn release. ([FFT Education Datalab](#))

→ **For your school:** *Worth checking against your own autumn-term figures if disadvantage-gap language is going into this year's SEF.*

SHEFFIELD & SOUTH YORKSHIRE

- **Newfield's first Ofsted since the Mercia takeover: a turnaround story.** Inspectors called Newfield Secondary (Norton Lees) 'warm, caring, calm, orderly and respectful' in its first report since Mercia Learning Trust took over in 2025, rating attendance/behaviour and inclusion at 'strong standard' — a marked shift after last year's contentious takeover, which included a pupil walkout over proposed arts cuts. ([The Star](#))

→ **For your school:** *A live example of inclusion recovering post-MAT-transition — useful if you're advising other schools going through the same.*

DATA POINT OF THE WEEK

3.8%

FFT Education Datalab's estimate of the combined suspension and exclusion rate in secondary schools, autumn term 2025/26 — down from 4.1% the year before.

FFT Education Datalab, 15 Sept 2026 (provisional)

MAPS IN PRACTICE – TOOL SPOTLIGHT: SCHOOL+

A strong inclusion strategy is only as good as the cohort picture beneath it.

School+ is the MAPs cohort-vulnerability framework — it maps who your at-risk pupils are and why, giving your inclusion strategy an evidence base rather than a wish list. [Explore School+](#)

SOURCES MONITORED

Weighted official- and evidence-first. X is monitored for early signals from official accounts and named commentators, and corroborated against a primary source before anything is included.

Source	Type	What we track
OFFICIAL & STATUTORY		
DfE / GOV.UK	Government	Policy, funding, statutory guidance and statistics
Ofsted	Government	Inspection framework, report cards, annual report
Explore Education Statistics	Government data	Exclusions, suspensions, attendance, census data
House of Commons Library	Parliament	Neutral briefings on bills and policy
RESEARCH & EVIDENCE		
Education Endowment Foundation	Research	Evidence-based guidance, incl. inclusive teaching
NFER	Research	Assessment, workforce, disadvantage
Education Policy Institute	Think tank	Policy analysis and the disadvantage gap
Institute for Fiscal Studies	Think tank	School funding and spending analysis
FFT Education Datalab	Data analysis	Data-driven analysis of attainment and exclusions
INCLUSION & PREVENTION SPECIALISTS		
The Difference	Charity	Whole-school inclusion; “Who’s Losing Learning?”
IPPR	Think tank	Lost learning, exclusions, SEND reform
Youth Endowment Fund	Research	What works to prevent youth violence & exclusion
Centre for Social Justice	Think tank	Exclusion tracker and social-mobility policy
Whole School SEND	Network	SEND practice, resources and reviews
SECTOR PRESS & COMMENTARY		
Schools Week	Press	Breaking sector news and investigations
Tes	Press	Practice, policy and workforce
The Guardian (Education)	Press	National coverage and comment
X (monitored)	Social	DfE, Ofsted, EEF and named voices — corroborated before use
LOCAL & REGIONAL		
The Star (Sheffield)	Local press	Local schools and Ofsted outcomes
Sheffield City Council	Local government	Council decisions, funding and local strategy
South Yorkshire MCA & Careers Hub	Regional	Regional skills, careers and funding

Connect Daily is part of Sheffield Connect. Compiled by Andy Marsden, Sector Inclusion Lead.

For circulation across the network and partners. Figures reflect the latest published data at the date of this brief.